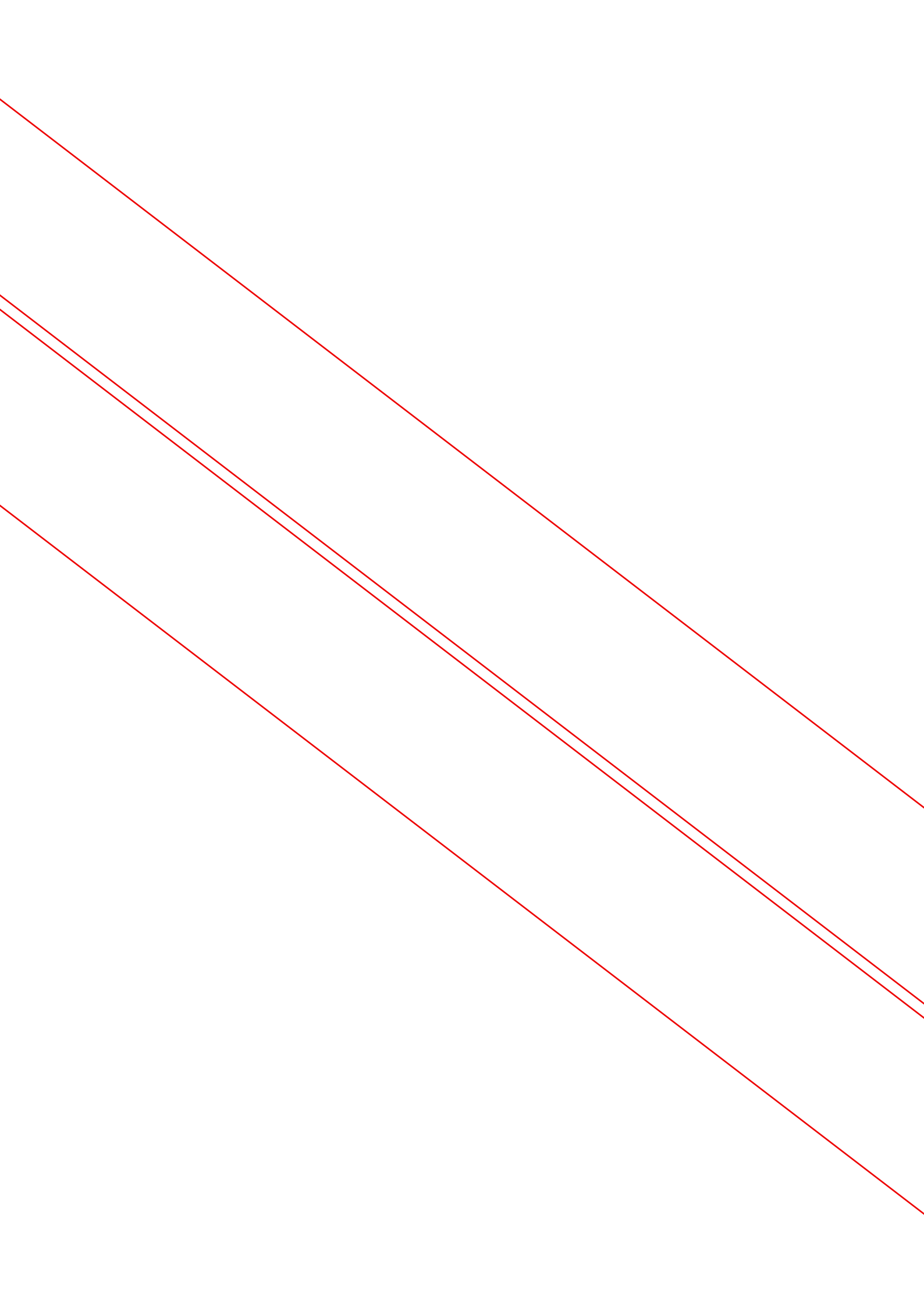
A Lifetime of Life in Time

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April 2026
Master Essay Fine Arts



whatever is infinite doesn't matter this is just a part of a lifetime of life in time
the city is an abysmal bore the morning after woke up the morning before and
went outside to start a day with a feeling that is no longer tied to the story every
morning the hood pops and starts to flicker lubricating cornea v6 misfiring
synapses like a g6 your former reflection can never be seen again dear phlegm,
got circumstantially old how much blood does it take for a date tree to grow

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Prologue

A will to start with an end and beginning at the same time both startles me and marks the following words as something slippery.

This essay is structured as a collection of fragments. Some kind of cartography of networks with different metaphors and stories with a reoccurring character named “P”, and some Arabic men. It is a fragmented mapping told through different events that either inform or reflect my artistic process over the past two years–or even longer.

I see it as an anachronistic journal that also carries some parts in dialogue with the physical work of my solo show, while other parts remain as open spaces that insist on a non-linear trajectory.

As I proceed to enter the slipperiness, I’m starting to feel a little bit *askew*…

A million different jackpots with a
thousand different gazes have led me to the
point where I must organize my thoughts
and fix my hearing.

I will start off by devoting my left ear to
attune itself to the left lane of my brain

Hood of the eye

At night, I like to doomscroll eastern
European Instagram reels of vintage
BMWs whilst my now, former partner
dreams about how her sleep schedule is
taking a gold medal in sleep.
The immense amount of time I spend
holding my phone with my right arm
wrapped around the pillow and my head on
top of it has caused a rounded right
shoulder and neck pain as if I have
received whiplash damage.
The kind of damage that disrupts the
neural pathways to the brain where the
common symptoms are a dysfunctional
ability to process visual input.

Every night ends in a small crash caused
by misfired synapses,
where my brain overcooks until my eyes
get covered by a hood that blocks them and
thickens my vision into absence.

Every morning, the hood pops with the
sound of a crunchy ignition,
and rhythmically starts to flicker by
moving downward and back up to smooth
a thin layer of tears across the cornea to
keep my bloodless eyes clear.

By slowly stretching out my right arm,
getting it ready
since it has to be

ready.

It is my rational arm,
the one who's always right.
It is something on the right side of my,

It is centered in the vehicle,
And in the right side of the vehicle,

Oh wait, the right,
passenger
of the day,
– "P".

P guides the heaviness of my right foot while I clutch.
Transmission.
Speed.
Driver.

But there's something about the flickering thing,
that just keeps flickering

the unstable
gap
of what has been seen,
of what is getting through,
nothing comes in full.

Right arm is now just a right arm.

Signal lights.

Red
Yellow
Green
Torque.

There you go,
all excited
make
new
meaning
of what just happened,
and where you are going

Accelerating,
into a collapsed horizon
eyes drained with coolant

New day, new misfire.
Looking at the world,
through a new window.

What happens when a conversation goes deeper than a cut?

When I first stood there, looking at my own reflection of the glass window whilst scratching my lopsided head, my hair looked like Saddam Husseins rough hairstyle when getting found by the American soldiers in 2003.

Around ten years later of that event, my father chose to return to Iraq from Sweden.
He first left the country around the first gulf war for Russia where he managed to impress my mom enough with his mediocre impasto paintings of flowers to then leave with her for Gotland due to the socioeconomic collapse of the Soviet Union.
He said he wanted to be close to his friends, as they were suffering under the oppression of the Islamic State.
Shortly after he left, I lost all his contact information and moved on with life since I was a 17-year-old teenager, only interested in everything, fun.

Cut to a few years later when my frontal lobe had just started to become, as 'they' say, fully developed. I started wondering what my father was up to, since my mother had recently passed.

About nine years had gone by and the year is now 2022, and winter.
I was sitting with a friend at a pub in Visby's old town, with a half-broken front tooth due to a snowball fight on the way there.
As we were indulging in cheap pints of beer, we were also planning how to go about finding my father.

At the time, I had just read poems from Ra'ad Abdulkadir, a pioneer of the Iraqi prose poem that chose to stay in Iraq during the war(s) where'd he wrote *Falk med sol.*
"Since most "intellectuals fled the country head over heels. Abdulkadir, however, stayed behind with death and constantly breathing down his neck. Those who didn't die at the front perished in the champers. Those who didn't die in the torture chambers succumbed in their sickbeds. And those who didn't die in their sickbeds died inside."
(Abdulkadir, 2022, cited in Mohamed, 2022, p.3, my translation)

Speaking of dying inside,
I wanted to know if he still was doing paintings.

Cut to just a week later within this story I'm slightly hesitating to tell.
And back to where I first started this page, –by seeing my own reflection of the glass window, I started to instead, look through it.
My attention got drawn to an absurdly looking phallic structure with spinning diagonal spirals in the color red and white, looking like they are endlessly rising or descending.

Whilst confusingly scratching my, again, lopsided head…
I think to myself, – this is a symbol, I have to get in.

As I enter this empty-looking space, I realize that it is the right spot to get a fresh cut, a barbershop.

Once inside, I chose to sit on the black leather couch to the left and patiently wait for the barber to come out. I pick up some kind of laminated menu that you usually can find in a Chinese restaurant. Parts of it have turned yellow probably due to the degradation of the plastic. I open it up and start flipping through the pages, where I come across different images of people's haircuts.

One of many cuts I see looks similar to the one Ronaldo was rocking during the 2002 world cup. Fully shaved, except for a semi-circular patch of hair left only on the front part of the forehead. This barbershop is either not up to date with their hair models, or they're just avantgarde as fuck!
Last time I visited my grandmother in Moscow, I remember the Slavic boys with blonde straight hair were running around showing off a similar cut but with the halfmoon being left as a fringe bouncing around covering their eyes.

Since I have now been greeted as the only customer inside, I am all of a sudden sitting in the barber's chair where I can see us both through the reflection of the mirror in front of us.

He fastens the cape around my neck like I already belong to him, and as soon as he places his hands on top of my head and checks the condition of my hair, he instantly asks me about my background.

Growing up as a child of immigrant parents in Sweden and getting asked that question has the possibility of creating a similar feeling to as if the barber would've all of a sudden pulled out his steel blade and put it against my throat as if it was a scene taken out of Sweeney Todd. Well, that was maybe a huge exaggeration, but at the same time necessary to put it out somehow. Nevertheless, this barber was not British. He tells me that he is Iraqi and just wonders if I am an Arab too.

As we continue chatting, he asks me which part of Iraq my father was from, and as I briefly told him about the situation, he immediately offered to help me find him by adding that he was from the same village. The conversation got deeper and ended with me sending the barber the last picture I had of my father along with his full name.

After a little while, the barber gets the job done. I pay up at the counter whilst still having the phallic thing spinning around in the *corner of my eye* and head towards the subway, leaving the place with my hair residue left on the floor; my body's own continuity feeling slightly perplexed, slightly *askew*.

I enter the metro station, run down the stairs and catch the green line going south.
As soon as the train hit the tunnel and the outside light disappeared,
the window lost its transparency by *turning into a dark mirror*,
where I could see my own reflection appearing and disappearing with the flashing lights,
– slowly realizing that the barber had basically cut only one half of my hair,
making my head look and feel like a waxing gibbous.

Cut to three weeks later where I am now in my studio,
and there's an unknown number calling.

I pick up and instead of presenting my name as if I am saying "Hey you have come to…", –I blow air into the speaker. This is such a silly thing, but I do it to "fool" the caller into thinking that there's wind or some kind of disturbance to the call, in order to let the person who is making the call make noise before me, so I can thereafter figure out if I can recognize who it is by the sound of their voice. It is something I do in case it could be the wrong person calling, or maybe just the last person I want to speak to.

I quickly recognized that it was the voice of the barber. He tells me that he and his friends in Iraq had gotten hold of a person but couldn't guarantee who it was, leaving me with a strangely long phone number that starts with the number five.

After spending a couple of days working up the nerve to give the number a shot, with some firm encouragement from my ex-girlfriend, who threatened to kick me out the door and send me into the forest to make the call, I finally do.

A few strange tones… a familiar voice answers; no need to blow any air into the speaker for any of the participants.

The barber's blade – and looking at the world through a trapezoid cut in three parts

Part one.
How does the symbolic value of a phallic
structure, or rather from now on, –a barber's
pole, *unfold* not only as a signifying object
for my blood, but also the bloody history of
the object itself?

Moving back in time to the Middle Ages, where vehicles were animal-drawn,
barbers did more than just cut hair where they also provided medical treatments like bloodletting. People believed that the body was made up of four fluids,
and if someone got sick, it was thought that one of the fluids was out of balance, where "bleeding was mainly left to barber-surgeons, who also cupped, pulled teeth, leeched, gave enemas, curetted fistulas, applied ointments, drained running sores, sutured wounds, removed superficial tumors, and stopped hemorrhaging.
All they seemed to need was *a good eye*, *a steady hand* and *a sharp blade*"
(Porter, 1997, p. 116).

During these procedures, "patients would tightly grasp a rod or staff tightly so their veins would show, where the barbers would *cut open* their arms and bleed them until they fainted.
After the procedure, the barber-surgeons "washed" the bandages which were hung outside on a pole to dry, and to advertise the therapeutic specialties offered in the barbershop. Flapping in the wind, the long strips of bandages would twist around the [wooden] pole in the *spiral pattern* [having the color red symbolizing blood, and white for bandage]."
(WordInfo, n.d.).

It's like the medieval version of what we today call a 'glow-up'!

Part two.
The spiral as a drill
and the oil as the fifth fluid.

During the 1920s and the mechanization of things in the United States, the barber's pole had now become kinetic, with a small motor making the spiral pattern spin so that it appears to again, –rise or descend endlessly. The 'design' had made its way from wood to kitsch,
and from advertising bloodletting – to a skin fade – or even a *buzz cut.*

The Americans also adapted the pole to include, a third spiral in the color blue, that of course was supposed to reflect the colors of their flag, which makes me want to *unfold* the pole one more time and briefly put it in a slightly wider perspective.
Maybe in relation to 'one of their' many oil industry booms.
Or to one of many in Iraq.
Maybe the one that is considered as one of the largest oil field that is called Baba Gurgur, (literally "Father of Fire"), – "famous for its 'Eternal Fire located in the middle of its oil fields that is estimated to have been burning over 4000 years and was described as far back as Herodotus ["the father of history"…] (Patowary, 2013).

Speaking of fathers of history, I remember being on the couch having a bowl of cereal with my Swedish friend whilst watching my father dancing around the TV,
celebrating that the 12-meter statue of Saddam was being televised when dropped to the ground by the Iraqi civilians with the help of U.S marines.

Poor Nils didn't seem to know what was going on!

Part three.
The irregular edge.

I think that we are trained to read the world as orthogonal because so much of what surrounds us is built that way: “the rooms we inhabit, the skyscrapers we work in, the grid-like arrangement of our streets and *freeways* we travel on our way to work speak to us in straight *lines*. … Two thousand years of geometrical training have engraved the grid in our minds” (Wertheim, 2008, p. 532).
With that being said, architecture, screens, interfaces, and even bureaucratic systems all reinforce some kind of ’90-degree grid logic’ that is supposed to bring order has shaped us.
Not to sound too crazy, but the screentime is actually killing me.
I have to stop doomscrolling or else I’d be doomed, – *it literally feels like I’m crashing every night*.
Tapping out from the rant, still feeling slightly *askew*. My point here is, and not to sound like Rudolf Steiner, that it’s maybe not only how we perceive the world, but also how we orient and align ourselves within it. I feel like we have become really good at squaring things off with our eyes through finding irregularities.

This leads me want to dissect the barber’s pole for the third and last time, by technically stripping it from its physical parts.

| If one takes out the middle part, which is the cylinder with the steep, red and white diagonal spiral, and *unfolds* it.
One will get a structure of a flat sheet that almost looks rectangular, where the top and bottom edges are parallel.
The only thing is that, the sides are angled to 35 degrees having the shape of a trapezoid. |



Mise en place (lit. “everything in its place”) – even the slippery fish

It feels familiar. It feels like the kitchen.

When I used to work as a *line* cook, it was me against the clock. As the tickets were stacking. New orders were shouted out loud for me to keep count of. Cook the dish, and hand it to the pass where it had to get plated with a silly tweezer by the head chef, –a composed dish by a non-composed maniac kind of scenario. As Anthony Bourdain said, “you’re only as good as your last plate”, which relates to the whole idea to cook or to get overcooked.

I think that an art practice is slightly similar to where you want to cook and make plate worthy food, only difference is maybe one of many distinctions between the expectations of a set menu, the service/preparation work around it, –and free expression.

But still, it is as if you are an employee of your own practice, –your own restaurant. By being the head chef and dishwasher at the same time you have the power to serve your guests empty pots and pans instead of foie gras and figs. It is a way of serving the unexpected, I guess. But while cooking you are still issuing instructions and cleaning up your own failures. Maybe I shouldn’t give the word failure its distinct meaning in relation to art, but at the same time, there’s, of course, an inner critic that works in high temperatures. And therefore, the problem is maybe not failure, it is just the heat and timing where every step bears the *risk* of either sustaining the process or exhausting it.

An example of that would be if the work contests with the next thought until it surrenders and confesses itself as a fraud just before being discarded and evaporated, just like a sauce reduction that never reached its initial ingredient. Or just like an overcooked turbot that never reached the pass. Only difference of that would of course be that *the fish* was already dead when it got delivered to the restaurant and metaphorically killed again by the cook. While in relation to an art practice, the work is to keep the fish alive by letting it flop on the water surface, as if it just got caught by your hand and still has the *slippery* potential of escaping. I think I’m trying to keep the poor fish on that threshold, since I am an artist now and not a cook anymore…

“Actualities from the past are an environment. They condition and produce a series of clinical signals or anatomical signs in the nervous system. At the center of that system–the nerve center–is the present: the core of all our entanglements, a map of historical and social conditioning. Contrary to fantasies of colonizing Mars … most of us will remain on Earth for the foreseeable future. We are very preoccupied here, scrapping around in our environments trying to piece together the worry, *fix the broken neurons, and understand, approximately, what happened*.” (Spooner, 2023, p 3.)

“Self-scripture as a Failure:” and the turbot as the lost neurotransmitter

Catch the fish, but do not squeeze the poor
thing. Look it in the eyes and remember it.
Let its slippery slime coat do its job and
leave it to escape into the deep ends of the
Baltic Sea.

We are now inside a cabin of a big boat in the synaptic gap located at the junction between two neurons, –the coastal capital city Stockholm, and the limestone stacked island of Gotland.

Whilst lying in one out of two separate bunks,
my Freudian psychoanalyst friend named P asks me what I’m reading under the night lamp. I reply that it is a text written by French philosopher Catherine Malabou,
–known for developing the concept of plasticity, that has something to do with an ‘active shaping’ of the brain, and that the text I’m reading is called – *“You Are Your Synapses”*.

P impulsively snatches the text from my hand and curiously begins flipping paper whilst reading aloud:

“Consciousness is nothing other than [‘how the owner of the movie-in-the-brain emerges within the movie’] … we need to grasp the essence of a person in the brain.”

P nods with a smile and continues:

“The essence of who you are is stored as synaptic interactions in and between the various subsystems of your brain. As we learn more about the synaptic mechanisms of memory, we learn more about the neural basis of the self.”

The structuralist in her smiles again and keeps reading…:

“*No one today is in a position to prove that all cognitive, emotional, or practical activities are the reformulated and resystematized equivalents of neuronal configurations. “I’ll state unashamedly from the start that we can’t … go all the way in formulating a complete synaptic theory of personality.”*

She nods again, but this time with a grim and continues reading while her voice gradually starts lowering into a murmur until it fades as she continues to silently mumble with her lips parted without her teeth moving into almost looking like the missing turbot:

“The space … and the cut that separate[s] the neuronal from the mental, … from different forms of consciousness, are comparable nor to synaptic gaps … but rather to theoretical [gaps] *that, in order to be minimized, require that scientific explanation be relayed on interpretation.”*
(LeDoux, 2002, cited in Malabou, 2008, pp. 57, 58, 62, 63)

She stops reading, puts away the text and looks at me.
I could clearly sense that she became a bit confused after dipping her toes into the philosophical trench since she lives in, what is known as, the real world, working with real things, and having Max Weber as her role model without probably knowing who he is. Or that is the impression I've got from P, since she likes to explain things to me in a very demystifying way.

In biology, the synaptic gap measures around 20 nanometers.
That is, 0.000020 millimeters.
What seems to me is that in P's interpretation of the gap, it runs through a *structural* engine of "healing", where therapy alone wraps words like bandages around that infinitesimal distance with the goal of the patient being enough recovered to be sent back into *society*.

I think that mine runs through a V6 engine that is either speeding on a highway into a collapsed horizon, or ramming into a wall, due to consuming slippery theory that yields a slippery understanding of 'what this is' or 'what is this'.
Maybe, it is,
–like driving a cool car that is not only functional,
–like getting a darker tint on your windshield every day.
The potency of risk…

In that cabin.
Reading the text with P, became another attempt of understanding or interpreting the gap as a physical phenomenon.

Every conceptualization of the synaptic gap happens *through its physical usage,* – a reciprocal nature which has been expanded on by my cabin mates, Old psychoanalyst friend P, Malabou, LeDoux, and me, the artist himself.

Located within the gap, where I could almost sense both the fragrant smell of tar coming from my childhood home, and the smell of stinky town Stockholm.

It's as if this very moment of interpreting the synaptic gap was like the boat had dropped its anchor into the marine abyss, looking for the missing turbot and finding it for a brief moment.

What I'm trying to anchor within myself,
what I'm trying to articulate,
requires an effort of 'understanding'
– as in, meaning-making as a metaphorical act.

the narrative
of who I think I am,
or the 'understanding'
of who I am,
is what
bridges
the gap
of
rewriting
the
script
Over,
and
Over,
until
infinite
regression
there's
an conflict
that is
the 'essence'
interrupted
history
leads to
broken
language
broken
neuron
ooh
the missing turbot
is exhausted

night lamp

off

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